

Jot Rev A: Hardware Architecture

Handheld push-to-talk voice capture device with BLE sync to an iPhone app

Document	JOT-HW-001
Revision	Rev A architecture, draft 4
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Status	Architecture agreed; parts selected and verified against datasheets; schematic capture next
Companion files	BOM/Jot_RevA_BOM.xlsx (parts, verification, design changes), BOM/Jot_RevA_Pin_List.xlsx (module pins, netlist), Datasheets/

1. Purpose

Jot is a pocketable device for capturing spoken notes. The user holds a side button, speaks, and releases. The recording is stored on the device first, then transferred to the iPhone app over Bluetooth Low Energy (BLE). The app transcribes the audio on the phone and turns it into notes, tasks, reminders, or calendar events. This document describes the Rev A custom PCB: what is on the board, how the blocks connect, and why each part was chosen.

2. Requirements

ID	Requirement	How Rev A meets it
R1	Hold to record; recording starts immediately, even from sleep	Button wakes the nRF52840 from System OFF; audio goes straight to local flash, no wait for BLE
R2	No lost recordings when the phone is out of range	128 MB flash buffer (roughly 18 h of Opus audio); clips sync when the phone reconnects
R3	Recording is always visible	Rec LED is powered from the same switched rail as the microphones
R4	Feedback without looking at the device	LRA haptic motor via DRV2605L; RGB status LED; 4 kHz buzzer
R5	Days of standby; accurate battery %	TPS7A02 LDO (25 nA quiescent current), System OFF sleep, MAX17048 fuel gauge
R6	Charge and update firmware over USB-C	USB data wired to the nRF52840; UF2 bootloader for drag-and-drop updates
R7	Simple pairing	NFC tag antenna on the PCB: tap Jot to the iPhone
R8	Room to improve audio later	Footprint for a second PDM mic (not populated on Rev A)

3. Block diagram

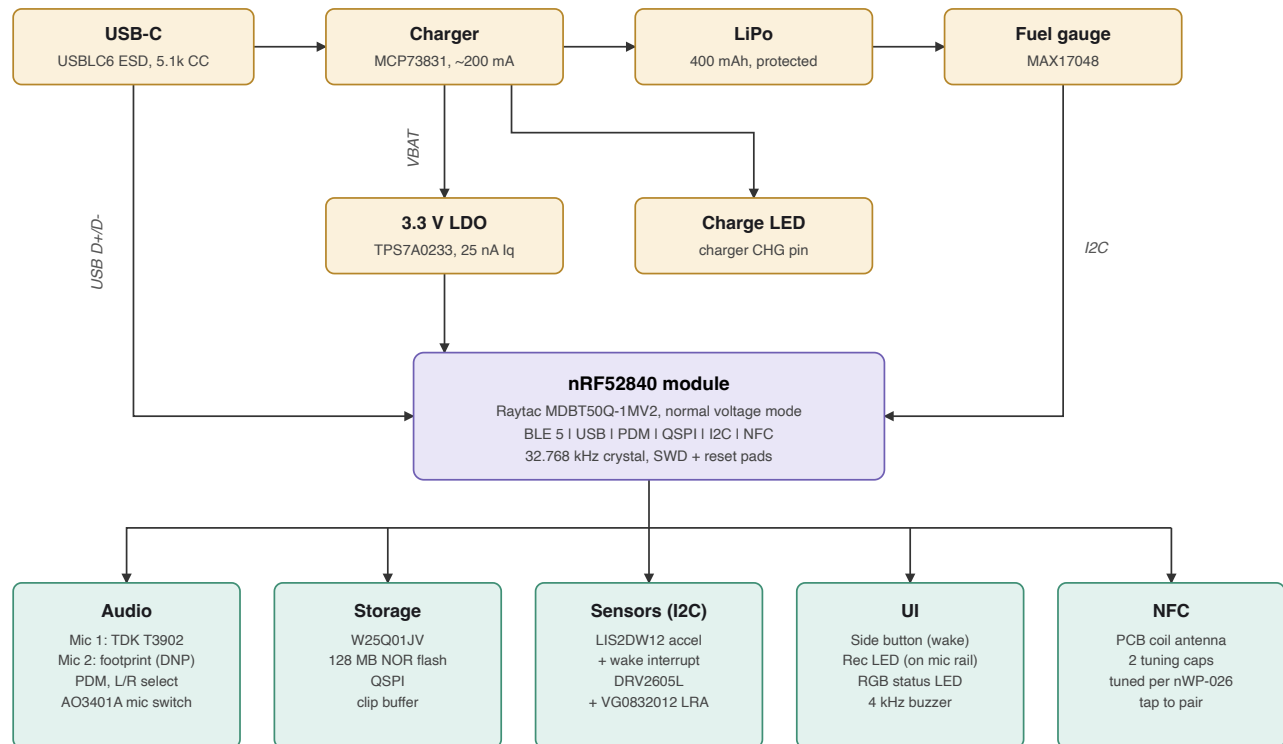


Figure 1. Rev A block diagram. Amber: power. Purple: microcontroller. Green: peripherals. The bottom groups connect to the module through the interfaces listed in Section 5.

4. Block descriptions

4.1 USB-C input

HRO TYPE-C-31-M-12 receptacle. Supplies 5 V for charging and carries USB data to the nRF52840. Two 5.1 k Ω resistors on the CC pins tell a USB-C charger to supply power; without them many chargers supply nothing. A USBLC6-2SC6 ESD protection part sits on the data lines because the connector is the part people touch. The module's VBUS pin is fed through a 2.2 Ω series resistor (R14), as the nRF52840 Product Specification recommends for new designs, with 10 μ F to ground.

4.2 Charger

Microchip MCP73831T-2ACI/OT single-cell LiPo charger in SOT-23-5. It stops at 4.2 V. A 5.1 k Ω PROG resistor sets the charge current to about 196 mA ($I_{REG} = 1000 \text{ V} / R_{PROG}$), which is 0.5C for the 400 mAh cell. VDD and VBAT each have 4.7 μ F, the datasheet minimum for stability when no battery is connected. The tri-state STAT pin pulls the green charge LED low while charging, so charging is visible even if the firmware is not running. There is no battery-temperature input; the pack has no thermistor. The system load runs from the battery rail, as on the XIAO nRF52840.

Draft 3 used a TI BQ25101. Its DSBGA package has 0.4 mm ball pitch, below the 0.5 mm minimum of JLCPCB's Economic assembly (Standard assembly needs a 70 $\times$ 70 mm panel), and it cannot be reworked by hand on a first board, so it was replaced before footprints were assigned.

4.3 LiPo battery

Adafruit 3898: one 3.7 V, 400 mAh lithium-polymer cell (about 36 × 17 × 7.8 mm) with its own protection circuit and a JST-PH lead. This is above the 150 to 350 mAh range first expected, so its fit must be confirmed when the case is designed. Check the lead polarity against the J2 footprint before first power-up: JST-PH polarity is not consistent between battery vendors.

4.4 Fuel gauge (MAX17048)

Estimates battery percentage from the cell voltage using a battery model, with no current-sense resistor. It is powered from the battery, reports over I2C (address 0x36), and draws only a few microamps, so it can stay on all the time. Its ALRT output can wake the nRF52840 on low battery.

4.5 3.3 V LDO

TI TPS7A0233 (200 mA, 25 nA quiescent current, 270 mV maximum dropout at 200 mA) converts the battery voltage (about 3.0 to 4.2 V) to 3.3 V for the module, flash, accelerometer, and mic switch, with 1 μ F on its input and output. Below about 3.5 V on the battery the rail follows the battery down; every 3.3 V part works down to at least 2.7 V. The nRF52840's internal high-voltage regulator (REG0) is not used: it starts at 1.8 V until firmware programs UICR.REGOUT0, which the 2.7 V minimum flash cannot run from, and it allows only about 25 mA for external loads, which a flash write (up to 25 mA) plus LEDs can exceed.

4.6 nRF52840 module

Raytac MDBT50Q-1MV2: a pre-certified module with chip antenna, so the RF design is already done and tested. It runs in normal voltage mode, following Raytac reference circuit 8.3: VDD and VDDH are tied to the 3.3 V rail with 10 μ F, and DCCH is left unconnected, so no REG0 inductor is needed. A Seiko SC-32S 32.768 kHz crystal (12.5 pF load, the maximum the nRF52840 supports) uses two 18 pF load capacitors, from the nRF52840 PS formula (section 5.4.2.4) $C = 2 \cdot C_L - C_{pin} - C_{pcb} = 2 \times 12.5 - 4$ (typical pin capacitance) $- 3$ (estimated board stray) = 18 pF. The stray is an estimate; check the LFXO frequency on the built board. P0.18 is kept as a pin reset on a test pad, alongside the SWD pads. The antenna end of the module goes at the board edge with no copper underneath, and away from the battery and the user's hand.

4.7 Audio

Mic 1 is a TDK T3902 bottom-port PDM MEMS microphone (64 dBA SNR, 1.65 to 3.63 V). It replaced the planned Infineon IM69D130 (69 dB SNR) because the T3902 is stocked at LCSC. Bottom port means the sound enters through a hole in the PCB under the mic; this fixes which board face points at the case opening. Mic 1's SELECT pin is grounded (right channel). A footprint for Mic 2 shares the same two PDM wires with SELECT tied high (left channel) and is not populated on Rev A (DNP). Both mics and the Rec LED are powered from a switched rail: an AO3401A P-MOSFET with a 100 k Ω gate pull-up, so the rail is off by default and on when the GPIO drives low. Firmware should release the PDM clock pin while the rail is off.

4.8 Storage

Winbond W25Q01JVZEIQ: 1 Gbit (128 MB) NOR flash on QSPI, WSON-8 8 × 6 mm, quad mode enabled at the factory. It is two stacked 512 Mbit dies with linear 4-byte addressing; each die reports its own BUSY bit. A 100 k Ω pull-up holds chip-select high while the nRF52840 powers up or resets, as Winbond requires. Recordings are written here first and deleted once the phone confirms it has them.

4.9 Sensors on I2C

LIS2DW12 low-power accelerometer (address 0x19, SA0 tied high: its internal pull-up cannot be switched off, so tying it low would draw about 150 μ A): detects raise-to-wake, double-tap, and shake in hardware and signals the nRF52840 on an interrupt pin, so the main chip can stay asleep. DRV2605L haptic driver (address 0x5A), powered from the battery with 1 μ F on VDD and on REG, drives a Vybionics VG0832012 LRA (8 mm coin, 235 Hz, 1.8 Vrms) for crisp taps from a built-in effect library. Both share the I2C bus with the fuel gauge; one pair of 4.7 k Ω pull-ups serves the whole bus.

4.10 UI

Side button: TS-1010-C-A right-angle tactile switch to ground, using the internal pull-up; it is also the wake source. Rec LED: red 0603 on the mic rail through 1 k Ω . RGB status LED: common-anode 1615 RGB with the anode on the battery rail. Each cathode is switched to ground by an AO3400A (gate from a PWM pin, 100 k Ω pull-down) through 1 k Ω (red) and 560 Ω (green, blue), about 2 mA at 3.7 V. Green and blue need about 2.6 V at 2 mA (up to about 3.0 V worst case), and the 3.3 V rail falls to about 3.0 V as the battery empties, so driving them from a 3.3 V pin left no headroom whatever the resistor; from the battery they stay lit down to 3.0 V, and no GPIO sees the battery voltage. Draft 2 drove a common-cathode TJ-S1615 from GPIOs through 100 Ω , which does not fix the headroom. Buzzer: MLT-5020 magnetic buzzer, 4 kHz, from the battery rail through a 10 Ω series resistor (the buzzer is rated 2 to 4 V and the battery reaches 4.2 V) and an AO3400A low-side MOSFET, with a 1N4148W flyback diode across the buzzer, for confirmation tones and a find-my-Jot feature.

4.11 NFC

The nRF52840 has an NFC tag built in. Rev A adds a coil antenna drawn in copper on the PCB and two equal tuning capacitors (C0G, 0402) from NFC1 and NFC2 to ground, forming an LC tank tuned to 13.56 MHz. Tapping Jot to the iPhone can open the app or start pairing. The tuning follows Nordic white paper nWP-026 (in Datasheets/NFC/):

$$C_{\text{tune}} = 2 / ((2\pi \cdot 13.56 \text{ MHz})^2 \cdot L_{\text{ant}}) - C_p - C_{\text{int}}, \quad C_{\text{int}} \approx 4 \text{ pF}$$

Coil inductance L_{ant}	1.0 μH	1.5 μH	2.0 μH	2.5 μH
Starting C_{tune} ($C_p = 0$)	~270 pF	~180 pF	~134 pF	~106 pF

Steps: (1) draw the coil once the board outline is known and calculate its inductance from its dimensions; (2) fit the estimated capacitor; (3) tune on the built board with a network analyzer (S11 dip at 13.56 MHz; lower C if the dip is above, raise it if below). Avoid the NFC Forum reference poller sizes (46 $\times$ 32 mm and 25 $\times$ 20 mm) to prevent overcoupling.

4.12 Power budget (estimate)

First-pass estimates from the component datasheets (typical values at 25 $^{\circ}\text{C}$), to be replaced by measurements at bring-up.

Mode	Current (typ)	Main contributors
Standby (System OFF)	≈ 10 to 17 μA	DRV2605L shutdown 4 μA , MAX17048 hibernate 3 μA , cell protection ≤ 7 μA (max), flash deep power-down 1 μA , LIS2DW12 low-power 1 μA , nRF52840 System OFF 0.4 μA
Recording (Opus, DC/DC on)	≈ 6.2 mA (≈ 9.2 mA with DC/DC off)	CPU 3.3 mA, Rec LED ≈ 1.3 mA, flash program and erase ≈ 0.6 mA, PDM ≈ 0.5 mA (assumed), mic 0.43 mA
BLE sync	≈ 8 mA for about 1 min a day	Radio TX at 0 dBm 6.4 mA, RX 6.3 mA

With 320 mAh usable (80% of 400 mAh), the electronics alone allow over two years of standby, so the cell's own self-discharge sets the real limit and R5 is met with a wide margin. A typical day (ten one-minute recordings and one sync) uses about 1.6 mAh, roughly 200 days per charge (about 150 days with the DC/DC regulator off). Firmware must put the flash into deep power-down before System OFF (in standby it can draw up to 170 μA), enable the DC/DC regulator, and keep the haptic driver's EN pin low.

4.13 Bring-up and test plan

Check the battery lead polarity, then feed the battery input from a bench supply at 3.7 V with a 50 mA current limit. Confirm the 3.3 V rail, that idle current is in the microamp range, and that nothing runs warm. Then, in order: probe the LDO output and the module's VDD; flash a blinky over SWD and check reset; scope the 32.768 kHz crystal once firmware starts it; read the flash JEDEC ID over QSPI, then write and read back across both dies; find the three I2C

parts (0x19, 0x36, 0x5A); switch on the mic rail, confirm the Rec LED, and capture and play back PDM audio; pair over BLE and transfer a clip; test USB charging and the UF2 bootloader. Finally, measure every mode on the battery input with a power profiler (Nordic PPK2) and update section 4.12 with real numbers.

5. Interfaces

Each connection in Figure 1 uses a standard interface. Knowing these makes the schematic much easier to read. The exact pin for each signal is in the pin list.

Interface	Wires	Used for	What to know
I2C	2 (SDA, SCL) + pull-up resistors	Fuel gauge, accelerometer, haptic driver	Shared bus; each chip has its own address (0x36, 0x19, 0x5A, no conflicts). Needs one pair of pull-ups on the whole bus, not one per chip.
PDM	2 (clock, data)	Microphones	Digital audio from the mic. Two mics can share the wires, one on each clock edge (left/right).
QSPI	6 (clock, chip select, 4 data)	128 MB flash	SPI with four data lines for speed. The nRF52840 selects QSPI pins in firmware; Rev A uses the nRF52840 DK's set (CSN P0.17, SCK P0.19, IO0 to IO3 on P0.20 to P0.23) with high-drive outputs. The PS lists P0.18/P1.00 as an alternative, but P0.18 is the reset pin.
USB	2 (D+, D-)	Firmware updates, debug	Full-speed USB is built into the nRF52840; no extra USB chip needed.
SWD	2 (SWDIO, SWCLK) + GND, 3.3 V, reset	Programming and debugging	Used with a debug probe for the first flash and for step-through debugging.
NFC	2 (NFC1, NFC2)	Coil antenna	Dedicated pins on the nRF52840; the coil and caps form a tuned circuit at 13.56 MHz.
GPIO / PWM	1 per signal	Button, LEDs, buzzer, mic power switch, interrupts	Plain digital pins. PWM sets LED brightness and buzzer tone. Pins near the radio are low-frequency only and carry only slow signals.

6. Key design decisions

Decision	Choice	Reason
Wireless link	BLE only, store-and-forward	Low power; recording never waits for a connection
Radio implementation	Pre-certified module, not a bare chip	Avoids RF layout risk on a first board
3.3 V supply	External TPS7A02 LDO; nRF in normal voltage mode	Correct voltage from first power-up and no 25 mA external-load limit, at 25 nA standby cost
Microphone	TDK T3902	In stock at LCSC; 64 dBA SNR. The IM69D130 (69 dB) was the first choice
Storage size	128 MB flash, not microSD	Clips only live on the device until synced; flash is smaller, lower power, no moving parts
Recording indicator	LED on the mic power rail	Recording cannot happen without the light being on
Haptics	DRV2605L + LRA	Crisp, phone-like feedback; effect library saves firmware work

Flash pins	nRF52840 DK QSPI pin set	Keeps P0.18 as a working pin reset; matches the DK's Zephyr board files
Second mic	Footprint only (DNP)	Keeps Rev A simple while leaving room for noise reduction later
Deferred to Rev B	Charging dock, wireless charging, display	Limits risk on the first spin

7. Open items

#	Item	Status	Outcome
1	Confirm the mic port type and LCSC stock	Done	TDK T3902 (bottom port, LCSC C3171752)
2	Pick the module and confirm it exposes the QSPI, USB, and NFC pins	Done	Raytac MDBT50Q-1MV2; all pins confirmed against its datasheet. Not stocked at LCSC: buy from DigiKey/Mouser
3	Pick the 128 MB flash part and confirm the Zephyr driver supports its 4-byte addressing	Part done	W25Q01JVZEIQ chosen. Confirm Zephyr 4-byte addressing and per-die BUSY polling during firmware bring-up
4	Select charger and LDO from in-stock LCSC parts	Done	MCP73831T-2ACI/OT (C424093), TPS7A0233 (C2887324). The BQ25101 was dropped in draft 4: its 0.4 mm BGA is below JLCPCB Economic assembly limits.
5	Choose the LRA size to fit the case	Part done	Vybrionics VG0832012 (8 mm); confirm fit in the case
6	Battery capacity and dimensions (set by the case)	Part done	Adafruit 3898, 400 mAh, 36 × 17 × 7.8 mm; confirm fit and lead polarity
7	Assign every signal to a module pin (pin map)	Done	See BOM/Jot_RevA_Pin_List.xlsx
8	NFC coil size and tuning capacitor values	Open	Method and starting values in section 4.11; coil depends on the board outline
9	Pick an in-stock common-anode 1615 RGB LED for the battery-rail drive (section 4.10)	Done	TOGIALED TJ-S1615SW6TGLCCYRGB-A5 (LCSC C273610), same family and pads as the common-cathode part it replaces: pin 1 anode, 2 blue, 3 green, 4 red. Q3-Q5 AO3400A with R15-R17 100k pull-downs; R8 1k, R9/R10 560 Ω. BOM and pin list updated 4 October.
10	Give the mic its own T3902 symbol	Done	Jot:T3902 symbol with the TDK datasheet and MPN; it keeps KiCad's Knowles LGA-5 footprint, whose pins, pads and port were checked against the T3902 datasheet and match. Netlist unchanged

8. Revision history

Draft	Date	Changes
1	October 2026	First architecture.

2	2 October 2026	Parts selected and checked against datasheets; mic changed to TDK T3902; external LDO confirmed (REG0 unused); R14 and 10 μ F decoupling added; QSPI pin note corrected; NFC tuning method added.
3	3 October 2026	Crystal load-cap calculation written out with board stray; RGB LED moved to the battery rail with low-side FETs; mic footprint checked against the T3902 datasheet; power budget and bring-up plan added. 4 October: accelerometer address changed to 0x19 (SA0 high) to avoid current through its internal pull-up.
4	5 October 2026	Charger changed from TI BQ25101 (0.4 mm-pitch DSBGA, not assemblable by JLCPCB Economic PCBA) to Microchip MCP73831 in SOT-23-5 with a 5.1 k Ω PROG resistor and 4.7 μ F on VDD and VBAT. Schematic review (4 October) added a 100 k Ω pull-up on the flash chip-select and a 10 Ω resistor in series with the buzzer.